

Intervals and absolute value equations

Exact determinant ranges of general tridiagonal interval matrices

Difficulty: challenging **Importance:** interesting to the community

Topic: interval linear algebra; determinants; computational complexity

Status: open; admitted after a bounded literature search found no resolution.

Problem statement

For $n \geq 2$, let the input consist of $3n - 2$ closed real intervals with rational endpoints: diagonal intervals $[a_i, \bar{a}_i]$ for $1 \leq i \leq n$, upper-diagonal intervals $[b_i, \bar{b}_i]$, and lower-diagonal intervals $[\underline{c}_i, \bar{c}_i]$ for $1 \leq i < n$. All lower endpoints are at most their upper endpoints. Define

$$\mathcal{T} = \{T \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n} : T_{ii} \in [a_i, \bar{a}_i], \quad T_{i,i+1} \in [b_i, \bar{b}_i], \quad T_{i+1,i} \in [\underline{c}_i, \bar{c}_i], \quad T_{ij} = 0 \text{ if } |i - j| > 1\}.$$

All uncertain entries vary independently. Does a deterministic algorithm exist that returns the two exact rational numbers

$$d_- = \min_{T \in \mathcal{T}} \det T, \quad d_+ = \max_{T \in \mathcal{T}} \det T$$

in time polynomial in the total binary input length? The target is the exact range $[d_-, d_+]$, including instances containing singular matrices and intervals crossing zero. Rational output is appropriate because the determinant is affine in each entry separately and its extrema are attained at endpoint matrices. The polynomial bound must be uniform in n .

References

Horáček, Hladík, and Matějka, *Determinants of interval matrices*, Electronic Journal of Linear Algebra 33 (2018), 99–112, §5.4, p. 106, immediately after Proposition 5.6; [journal PDF](#). The corresponding location in [arXiv:1809.03736v1](#) is §6.4, p. 9, after Proposition 6.7. The source proves polynomial computability for interval tridiagonal H-matrices and explicitly leaves general tridiagonal interval matrices open.

Status check (2026-09-08)

Searches for *tridiagonal interval determinant complexity*, *tridiagonal determinant range*, and *tridiagonal interval determinant polynomial 2026* found no resolution for independent-entry exact ranges. Two superficially conflicting Thirupathi–Thamaraiselvan papers, *Symbolic Algorithm for Inverting General k-Tridiagonal Interval Matrices* and *A Symbolic Algorithm for Solving Doubly Bordered k-Tridiagonal Interval Linear Systems*, both published in 2023, use different generalized arithmetic (§2.2, pp. 3–4). Their multiplication centers the result at the product of midpoints and takes the smaller distance to the standard product endpoints. Consequently it sends $[1, 2]$ and $[2, 3]$ to $[2, 11/2]$, while independent products range over $[2, 6]$. Their symbolic determinant algorithms therefore do not establish exact ranges in the sense defined above.